



Australian Government  
Australian Maritime Safety Authority



# AMSA Safety Alert

## Float-free EPIRBs

## New requirements commencing 1 January 2021

### The purpose

This safety alert aims to raise awareness of the need for owners, operators, masters and crew of certain domestic commercial vessels (DCVs) to install a float-free emergency position indicating radio beacon (EPIRB) **before 1 January 2021**.

You will need to install a float-free EPIRB if your vessel is operating more than two nautical miles from land and:

- is more than 12 m in length, or
- is between 7.5 m and 12 m in length with no level-flotation fitted, and operating in B or C waters

[Find out more about if this applies to you.](#)

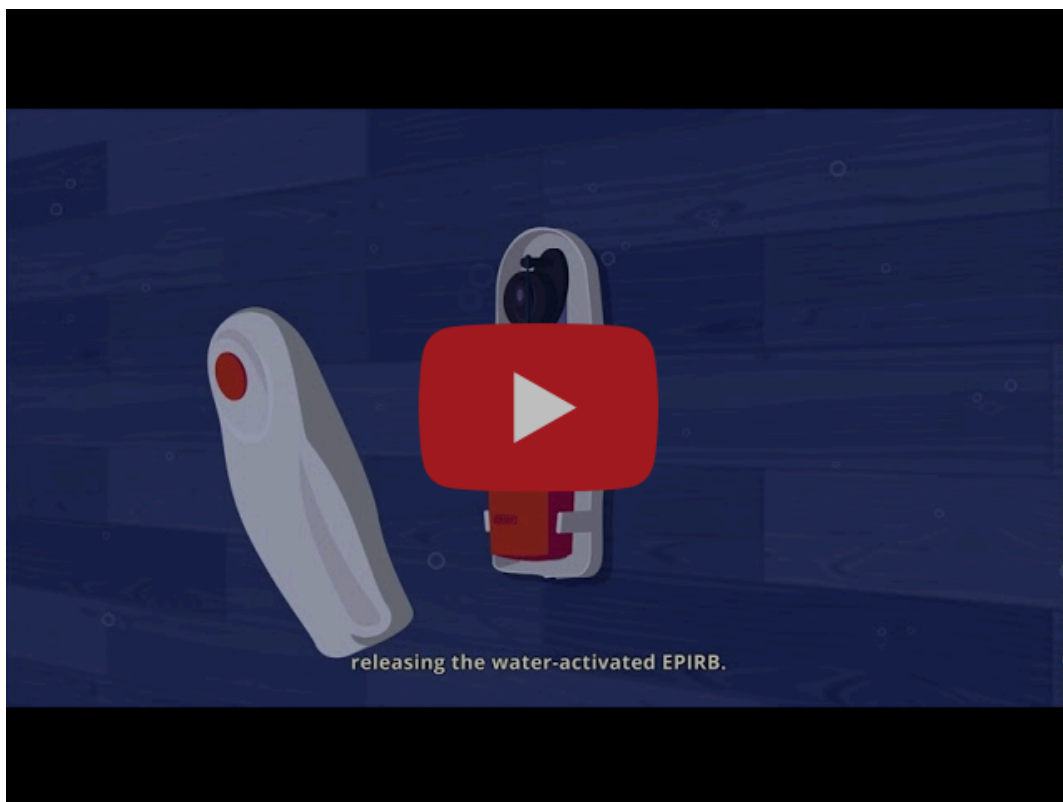
## Why are float-free EPIRBs required?

The requirement to install a float-free EPIRB is in response to incidents where commercial vessels have sunk too quickly for the crew to deploy their EPIRB in time, leading to a delay in search and rescue operations and a tragic loss of life.



- A float-free EPIRB is a water-activated distress beacon fitted in a float-free bracket.
- It is designed to activate when a vessel sinks to a depth of 1–4 metres.
- It uses a hydrostatic release device and a water-activated switch.
- With a clear path, it floats to the surface and transmits a distress signal.
- A float-free EPIRB can also be manually activated in the event of an emergency.

**This video shows how a float-free EPIRB automatically deploys underwater.**



## Installation of float-free EPIRBs

The effectiveness of a float-free EPIRB depends on where the unit is mounted on the vessel. A float-free EPIRB should be mounted:

- on the outside of the vessel. Note—the vessel may roll over when sinking, so take this into consideration when deciding where to mount it
- in a clear open space away from any obstructions so it can float to the surface
- where it is easy to access in an emergency and if manual activation is required
- in an area where it won't be impacted by high-pressure water spray and inclement sea states
- where it is protected from damage.

Manufacturers include detailed advice on how to install and maintain a float-free EPIRB in their instruction manuals.

This video includes information about the use and installation of float-free EPIRBs.



## Safety management system

Make sure your safety management system (SMS) includes:

- emergency procedures, taking into account the location of the float-free EPIRB and when manual activation may be required
- training and induction for crew members on the use of and location of the float-free EPIRB
- ensuring the float-free EPIRB is correctly mounted in its bracket as part of pre-departure checks
- planned maintenance and inspection of your float-free EPIRB, its bracket and hydrostatic release unit
- periodic testing of your float-free EPIRB in accordance with the manufacturer's instructions, to ensure it will transmit properly in an emergency situation
- registration details of your float-free EPIRB, and a reminder to check and update the details.

## Common issues to avoid

To ensure correct activation of your float-free EPIRB and reduce the likelihood of accidental activations, the following advice should be considered

- Each float-free EPIRB model comes with its own bracket. To ensure EPIRBs activate correctly, do not use a different make or model bracket.
- Ensure the float-free EPIRB cord does not get caught in the bracket lid.
- Do not attach the float-free EPIRB cord to the vessel.
- Ensure the float-free EPIRB is correctly mounted in the bracket.

## Compliance

The requirement to have a float-free EPIRB on certain vessels was announced in July 2018. Hence, owners have had over two years in which to purchase and install one. If you haven't already installed a float-free EPIRB, you are strongly encouraged to do so as soon as possible. If you do not have a float-free EPIRB properly installed and registered with AMSA by 1 January 2021, you can expect appropriate compliance action to be taken.

## Benefits of GPS

A GPS-equipped float-free EPIRB can mean all the difference in an emergency situation. GPS-equipped EPIRBs provide a much more accurate location to search and rescue authorities. AMSA strongly recommends the installation of a GPS-equipped EPIRB.

The infographic features a dark blue background. On the left, there is a stylized illustration of an AMSA EPIRB (Emergency Position Indicating Radio Beacon) with a white antenna, a grey top section labeled 'AMSA', an orange middle section labeled '406 MHz', and a red bottom section labeled 'GPS EPIRB'. To the right of the EPIRB, the text 'GPS is BEST' is written in large, white, bold letters. Below this, a light blue arrow points to the right, containing the text 'With GPS' and 'Accurate to within 120m'. The background of the infographic is a satellite image of a coastal area with a city and a large bridge. A circular inset provides a closer view of the bridge. At the bottom, a dark blue banner contains the text 'Without GPS' and 'Accurate to within 5km'.

# GPS is BEST

**AMSA**  
**406 MHz**  
**GPS EPIRB**

**With GPS**  
Accurate to within 120m

**Without GPS**  
Accurate to within 5km

## Registration

A registered EPIRB allows AMSA search and rescue to phone your emergency contacts and look up important information about your vessel, and to initiate a response as soon as possible. An unregistered EPIRB can cause a delay in the response.

It is mandatory to [register your EPIRB](#).

## Reminder

- Ensure the float-free EPIRB is installed on the vessel and maintained in accordance with the manufacturer's instructions.

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- Ensure your EPIRB is inspected and tested regularly.
- Review your risk assessment and SMS for your operation.
- Ensure your EPIRB is registered with AMSA and all your details are up to date.

## More information

Should you require any further assistance or information, please contact AMSA Connect on 1800 627 484, +61 2 6279 5000 or via email to [AMSAConnect@amsa.gov.au](mailto:AMSAConnect@amsa.gov.au)

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